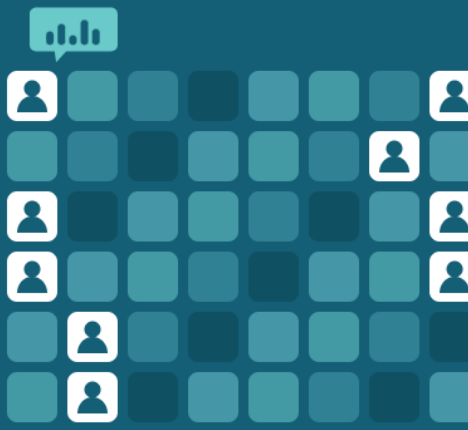
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 0: Welcome to place-based data training



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

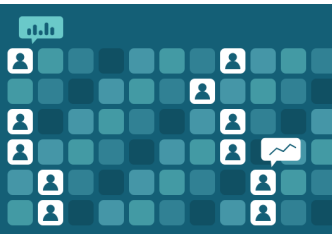
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Module

0 Welcome to place-based data training

Section 1 **Working with data in place-based work** 5 activities

Which of these sounds most like you?

Introduction

- You are already drawing on numbers, stories or observations in your work.
- You know your community deeply and are building your confidence in working with data.
- You want to strengthen how you use data to inform decisions, support learning and understand change.
- You are curious about working with data in place-based work and want to understand what it involves.

My response

Take a moment

Learn

Take a moment: which of the four roles feels most familiar to you? Which would you like to strengthen through this training? Keep that in mind as you move through the modules.

My response

Try this now: take stock of what you already have

Apply | Apply to your place 1

You may already be working with more data than you think. Take a few minutes to notice what is already part of your work.

Think about your current work. Identify three examples of data you already use or draw on. For example, this might be:

- Something community members have told you
- Service or program information
- Enrolment, population or other statistics
- A research or evaluation report
- Observations or insights from your work

Add one example to each row below. For each one:

Which source? Which of the four **Place-Based Data buckets** does it fit most closely: Community Insights, Government Data, Service Data, or Research and Evidence?

What does it help me understand? What does this data tell you about your community?

What else might I need to know? What can't you understand from this data alone? What other information or perspectives might help?

What I already have	Which source?	What does it help me understand?	What else might I need to know?

> Now look across your three examples. What do you notice?
>
> Are there particular sources you tend to draw on more than others? What can you understand from what you already have? What questions remain?
>
> This is only a starting point. You don't need data from every source for every question. The important thing is to notice what your existing data can help you understand, and when another source or perspective might help you see something more.

Take a moment

Learn

Take a moment: think about data you already use in your own work. What would it take for the people it describes to feel it was being used respectfully, openly and for their benefit?

My response

Try this now: write down your question

Apply Apply to your place 2

Everything ahead works better if you bring a real question with you.

Think of one question about your community that better data could help you answer. Something people are wondering about, trying to understand or need to make a decision about.

For example: What is changing for young people in our community? Where should we focus our efforts? What are we learning about what is working? Are we beginning to see the changes we hoped for?

Your question doesn't need to be perfect. Choose something that you would genuinely like to better understand.

Now think about your question from a few different angles:

- Which of the **Four I's** does it most closely relate to? Are you primarily trying to build insight, inform a decision, improve through learning and adaptation, or understand impact?
- Who might need to be involved? Think about who holds relevant knowledge, experience or data, including people in the community, local organisations, service providers, government or others.
- What might you need to consider? Think about whose perspectives are represented, where the data comes from, whether consent or permission is needed, and how the data should be handled and used.

My question	Which of the Four I's does it most closely relate to?	Who might need to be involved?	What might I need to consider when collecting or using data to answer this question?

> Keep your question somewhere you can return to it. Later modules will introduce different ways to explore questions like this, so you can keep applying what you learn to something that matters in your own work.